

TIEEDI FOREST GARDEN

UTSOW PRADHAN, 42

IN A FORMER LIFE: Product manager at an edtech firm

Where: 1-acre food forest in Darjeeling, West Bengal

Motivation: "I grew up in the hills, close to nature, but I studied and worked in several cities for the next 18 years of my life. However, I couldn't help but notice the drying of the local river, Hussel Khola, in Kurseong, the river I grew up with. Permaculture, I believe, is the perfect system with the tools to help reverse the damage to our ecology. I moved back to correct the wrongs"

Revenue stream: Workshops, partnerships with schools, farmstays, zero-waste event management and consultation

ECONOMICS OF A PERMACULTURE FARM

- 1-2 acres of land is enough to meet the yearly requirement of fruits and vegetables for a family of 4-6 members. If grains are to be included, then 4-5 acres might be required
- Food prices are benchmarked against the 'market' rates, so selling the organic produce isn't a viable business model unless it's a huge farm, or you have access to a market that sells organic produce
- Alternative revenue streams are created through permaculture design workshops, sustainability courses, farm stays, yoga and spiritual retreats, volunteering activities, or even a line of organic value-added products such as jams, preserves, pickles, spices and chutney powders. Cost of workshops can go from Rs 2,000 for a day to Rs 25,000 for a 15-day permaculture design course

BENEFITS OF LIVING OFF THE LAND

- Live in sync with nature
- Food security
- Access to seasonal, nutrition-dense food
- Intangible benefits such as better health, good quality air
- Reduced carbon footprint
- Ecological benefits to soil through mulch, composting, groundwater recharge via water bodies

with some 'insectary' flowering plants that serve as biological pest control by attracting insects that discourage pathogens. Additionally, nitrogen-fixing plants may be integrated into the scheme to maintain soil fertility.

However, permaculture extends beyond food cultivation, encompassing a set of three social principles: Earth care, people care and fair share. In this ethos, knowledge-sharing and community engagement become integral facets of the permaculture way of life. "Permaculture is all-inclusive, it is not about creating an oasis amidst degenerate surroundings. It's about generating multiple ripple effects, collectively fostering resilient communities," says Solanki whose initiative, swaYYam, works with neighbouring villages on issues such as deforestation, soil conservation and water harvesting.

Darjeeling-based Tieedi Forest Garden (where Tieedi stands for 'Take it easy, easy does it') collaborates with neighbouring villages to facilitate their transition to zero-waste status. "We have established a framework—a zero-waste village is one that refrains from burning any waste, composts all biodegradables and gives non-biodegradables to NGOs like ours for processing," says its founder, Utsow Pradhan. If a village is able to do this for six months, it earns the distinction of a zero-waste village. Since it started work in 2022, three villages have achieved the zero-waste designation.

The scope of work extends to creating habitats for wildlife as well. Tieedi even has a resident bear that claims one of their composting pits as a seasonal abode. "He appears each September and stays till November before going into hibernation in the winter months," says Pradhan. "He doesn't harm anyone, not even the chickens. In fact, it contributes its bit by turning the compost and sparing us the labour-intensive work."

MAKING A LIVING

Permaculture farms emulate thriving forest ecosystems and, hence, are largely self-sufficient. The model is heavily influenced by Japanese farmer Masanobu Fukuoka and his 'one-straw revolution', championing the cause of "do-nothing